tre's relationship with states should be managed cooperatively but with adequate delegation in order to aid the real economy and finance public expenditures. Here, too, Dr Rangarajan's chairmanship of the 12th Finance Commission in 2002 led to a significant revamp of state financing, the issuance of state development loans, and a gradual weening away of states from the Centre for financing purposes.

With so many accomplishments, one might be tempted as an author to engage in the occasional flourish or romanticism around the ideas. But Dr Rangarajan succumbs to no such temptation. His writing style is dispassionate and self-effacing,

THROUGHOUT THE BOOK, ONE CAN SEE DR RANGARAJAN'S UNERRING FOCUS ON GROWTH

focusing on the substance of what was attempted and achieved. He is generous in sharing the glory of the achievements of his tenure in various positions with others who made it all possible. Most noteworthy is the fitting dedication of the book to the then-finance minister Dr Manmohan Singh, with whom he shared a mutually respectful and highly productive partnership, and "whose vision and courage opened up new vistas and opportunities for India".

The book can be read by anyone interested in commerce, central banking, economics and financial markets. In fact, even if one is not well-versed in economics, the significance of the text to what India is today ought to interest the reader to learn more about economics. 'Some Ruminations', the book's last chapter, is in itself a most readable, standalone, fact-based summary of India's evolution from the largely state-controlled era of the pre-1990s to the present form that has benefited from the well-calibrated, gradual but decisive and, ultimately, definitive liberalisation reforms.

The text uses delightfully pithy and transparently honest sentences. To give an example, here is a sentence from the book's Introduction: "Many people ask me, 'Did you enjoy being governor of RBI?' My answer is, 'I am enjoying it in retrospect.' At that time, when we were dealing with the crisis and later with the reforms, it was not smooth sailing. There were moments of acute anxiety and concern." Laying bare his vulnerabilities as a decision-maker and yet quietly resolving all dilemmas is the hallmark of Dr Rangarajan's personality and the deft practice of his craft at economic policy-making.

Throughout the book, one can see Dr Rangarajan's unerring focus on growth. He sees price stability, that is, keeping inflation in check, as essential to sustained growth. He underscores throughout the importance of equitable growth, clarifying in fact that one can't sequence high growth and equity in that order, the two steps must be undertaken in tandem for a balanced gait of the economy. "Therein lies economics wisdom and economic statesmanship," he asserts.

Today, more and more countries, even developed ones, are confronting the difficult-to-navigate policy space where fiscal and central banking arithmetic are at odds with each other, a challenge that only gets compounded by its impact on markets. It is a low-frequency cycle that keeps repeating itself. In my assessment, therefore, *Forks in the Road* deserves to reach the status of a timeless classic in economic history, not just for Indian readership but globally. ■

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